evocative of the divinities in whose natures they participate, which are used in rituals. Attached to each *Samhita* are texts called *Brahmanas* which prescribe, describe and elucidate the purposes of the sacrificial rituals. They posit correspondences between aspects of the rites and features of the macrocosm, the social structure and the human body. It was believed that ritual performance orders, sustains and perpetuates the universe, creating new time and ensuring the regular succession of the seasons. There are also the *Aranyakas* ('Forest Books') that speculate about the 'inner' meaning of the rituals and are closely associated with the ***Upanishads***.

Some *Rig Vedic* hymns contain speculations of a cosmological and metaphysical nature. *Rig Veda* 10.129 asks what there was before existence (*sat*) and non-existence (*asat*) prior to death and immortality, light and dark. The hymn conveys a sense of genuine philosophical perplexity and awe. Such inquiries will come to fruition in the ***Upanishads***.

Further reading: Flood 1996; Gonda 1975; O'Flaherty 1981

Vedanta (lit. 'end of the Veda' = the ***Upanishads***): *Vedanta* or *Uttara Mimamsa* is the systematic interpretation of the ***Upanishads*** either by direct commentary upon them or by explanation of the summaries of their contents in the ***Brahma-Sutras***. The ***Bhagavad Gita*** is also a key authority. Most *Vedantins* were worshippers of *Vishnu*. There are three antagonistic schools: ***Advaita*** (Reality is non-dual), ***Vishishta-advaita*** (Unity of Complex Reality) and ***Dvaita*** (Dualism). They all agree that eternal scripture (***shruti***) is the sole means of knowledge (***pramana***) for what is beyond the scope of sensory perception and inference. *Vedantins* hold that it is the ***Upanishads*** (the knowledge portion or *jnana-kanda* of the ***Vedas***) that